

## 2 Subject content and assessment information

This qualification supports students in forming personal and meaningful relationships with music through the development of musical knowledge, understanding and skills including performing, composing and appraising. The qualification encourages students to engage critically and creatively with a wide range of music and musical contexts, develop an understanding of the place of music in different cultures and contexts, and reflect on how music is used in the expression of personal and collective identities.

This qualification also supports the development of musical fluency and provides access to further study of music at AS and A Level.

### Qualification aims and objectives

The aims and objectives of this qualification are to enable students to:

- engage actively in the process of music study
- develop performing skills individually and in groups to communicate musically with fluency and control of the resources used
- develop composing skills to organise musical ideas and make use of appropriate resources
- recognise links between the integrated activities of performing, composing and appraising and how this informs the development of music
- broaden musical experience and interests, develop imagination and foster creativity
- develop knowledge, understanding and skills needed to communicate effectively as musicians
- develop awareness of a variety of instruments, styles and approaches to performing and composing
- develop awareness of music technologies and their use in the creation and presentation of music
- recognise contrasting genres, styles and traditions of music, and develop some awareness of musical chronology
- develop as effective and independent learners with enquiring minds
- reflect on and evaluate their own and others' music
- engage with and appreciate the diverse heritage of music, in order to promote personal, social, intellectual and cultural development.

# Component 1: Performing

---

## Overview

The purpose of this component is to assess students' performing skills in both a solo and ensemble context. Students should be given the opportunity to rehearse and refine performances on their chosen instrument or voice, developing technical control, expression and interpretative skills.

This component will encourage students to develop creative thinking, aesthetic sensitivity, critical awareness, self-confidence, self-motivation and their own musical interests and skills. This includes the ability to make music individually and in groups, and perform with control, using phrasing and dynamics appropriate to their chosen styles and moods of music.

The areas of content covered are:

- solo performing
- ensemble performing
- approaches to performing.

Students must perform:

- solo performance: this must be of at least one minute in duration, and may comprise one or more pieces
- ensemble performance: this must be of at least one minute in duration, and may comprise one or more pieces.
- total performance time across both performances must be a minimum of four minutes of music.

## Content

Students will have to perform a solo and an ensemble performance. These must be different pieces of music for each performance. The following content explains what must be learned for each type of performance. It explains the possible approaches that can be applied to each student's performance as is desired and appropriate.

The music vocabulary list in *Appendix 3* details the musical elements, musical contexts and musical language that students should know and use as appropriate depending on the choice of instrument and piece in their performances.

Students will be required to demonstrate the ability to:

- make use of musical elements, techniques and resources to interpret and communicate musical ideas with technical control and expression. This must be achieved by one or more of the following means: playing or singing music, improvising, or realising music using music technology
- perform music with control, making expressive use of phrasing and dynamics appropriate to the style and mood of the music
- students will be assessed on their skills demonstrated during a live, unedited, uninterrupted performance. Recordings of performances (using any instruments and/or technology) may not be edited afterwards
- for this component, students can use any instrument for their solo and/or ensemble pieces, including those that make use of music technology (e.g. electric guitar).

## **Solo performances**

A solo performance is considered to be a piece in which the student's part plays a significant or leading role, its contribution to the music is distinctive and clearly recognisable in its individuality. The performance may be on any instrument or voice in any style or genre.

Music that was written with an accompaniment must be performed with that accompaniment. The accompaniment should not be altered to double the solo line. The usual accompaniment for a solo performance will be by one other performer on a contrasting instrument. For instance, a singer, flautist or trombonist may be accompanied by a pianist, a jazz saxophonist may be accompanied by a double bass player. However, students are able to perform with a larger ensemble where there is a clear solo part throughout and where the music was originally written for these instrumental and/or vocal forces.

Performances accompanied by backing tracks are acceptable but the part to be assessed must not be audible as part of the backing track.

## **Ensemble performances**

An ensemble performance must consist of two or more performers, playing undoubled and simultaneously sounding, independent parts (for at least one minute), with or without additional backing or accompaniment as appropriate.

When performing their ensemble, students should, in addition to accuracy and other essentials of effective performance described above, pay attention to balance and the reaction and adjustment to other parts. These are specifically assessed in assessment grids 2 and 3.

A solo with an accompanist is not acceptable as an ensemble unless the student being assessed is the accompanist.

Backing tracks may be used to accompany an ensemble performance but would not count towards a live instrumental part. The part to be assessed must not be audible as part of the backing track.

## Approaches to performing

All students should listen to how established performers communicate. They should appraise their use of articulation, phrasing and dynamics in the light of these performances and reflect this when shaping their interpretation of their chosen music. All students should know and understand the appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology related to their performances.

For both their solo and ensemble performances, students will need to understand the following as appropriate for their chosen performance.

- Performing from a score. A score can mean staff notation or written instructions for the playing of a piece of music. Students should learn the importance of attention to intonation, tuning, and accuracy of pitch and rhythm when performing from a score. They should work on their instrumental tone and technique, and ensure that they observe all performance directions for phrasing, articulation, dynamics and tempo. They should also recognise the importance of fluency and ensure that the overall outcome is effective in terms of communication, interpretation and style.
- When performing from a score, students should understand the contextual influences affecting the composition of the pieces they are performing, including the composer's intentions regarding the venue and nature of the performance, and any important cultural influences relating to the composition of the piece.
- Students who choose to improvise should learn to play the music accurately and go on to exploit and develop its potential. They should pay attention to intonation, tuning, coherence and to structure generally. They should work on their instrumental tone and technique and demonstrate their ability to shape the music effectively. They should also recognise the importance of fluency and ensure that the overall outcome is effective in terms of communication, interpretation and style, for example with jazz music.
- Performance of a live part over a pre-recorded/sequenced backing track. If choosing this approach, students must play the live part, and it is only this live part that will be assessed during their performance. This final part must be performed in real time. Students are not permitted to edit their sequenced recordings after their live performances.
- For rapping (similar to vocal performances) students should demonstrate clarity of diction, secure breath control, tonal contrast and some extended vocal techniques. Students choosing to beatbox should create a variety of contrasting timbres and demonstrate effective control of rhythm.

- Students may choose to perform by the oral tradition that does not fall under solo improvisation or traditional performances. In this context, oral tradition means material and tradition transmitted orally from one generation to another, often taking the form of folktales, ballads, songs, or chants.
- Students may perform their own compositions when supported by a score with sufficient performance detail to assess the accuracy of pitch and rhythm.

## **Musical elements**

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music performed, students should use the appropriate musical elements in their performance.

The musical elements are listed below:

- organisation of pitch
- tonality
- structure
- sonority
- texture
- tempo, metre and rhythm
- dynamics.

## **Musical contexts**

Students should take into account the effect of the purpose and intention of their piece of music, and the effect of audience, time and place when performing their pieces. Students should perform their music with control, expressing the music as appropriate to its style and mood.

## **Musical language**

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music, students should be able to read and play music using the appropriate musical language.

Different types of musical language are listed below:

- reading and writing of staff notation
- major and minor chords and associated chord symbols
- recognising and accurately using appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology related to the areas of study.

## Performing using music technology

Students may perform using music technology. Music technology may involve the use of synthesisers, virtual instruments and amplified instruments, such as guitars using pedals (including loop pedals), audio samples, and other processors.

Students will be assessed on their ability to perform a live solo line, which may (or may not) include playing over a pre-recorded/sequenced backing track (which may or may not have been created by the student themselves). This pre-recorded/sequenced backing track is not assessed.

Examples of how to play the live solo line might include by electric guitar or synthesiser, with live use of effects and processes.

## Assessment information

- First assessment: 2018.
- This component consists of 60 marks.
- Students must perform as a soloist and as part of an ensemble. Each performance must last a minimum of one minute, with a combined duration of at least four minutes. Each performance can consist of one or more pieces.
- For performances that **do not** meet the total minimum time requirement, the total performance mark will be reduced proportionally according to how many seconds the combined performance is less than four minutes. This will be applied by Pearson during the moderation process. Please see *Appendix 9: Mark penalty tables for submissions not meeting the minimum assessment time*.
- The final performances will be carried out under controlled conditions.
- Performance recordings must be submitted at the end of the course by 15 May.
- Centres must ensure that the performances submitted are valid for the series in which they are submitted.

Students will perform as a soloist and as part of an ensemble:

- Solo performance: students will perform a minimum of one solo piece (of at least one minute) of their own choice in any style or genre, with or without accompaniment as appropriate to the style of the music
- Ensemble performance: students will perform a minimum of one piece as part of an ensemble (of at least one minute) in any style or genre. The student's part must not be doubled by any other member of the ensemble.

The same music may not be used for solo performance and ensemble performance. The combined duration of the two performances must be at least four minutes.

More than one student may be assessed in the course of a single ensemble performance.

## Performance task setting, taking and assessment

### Task setting

Students should choose the performances they want to perform with the support of their teacher.

Each performance should be of sufficient length and complexity to give the performer adequate opportunity to demonstrate their abilities. The teacher should ensure that the level of demand is appropriate to allow the student to present a personal and meaningful response.

Teachers should ensure that the performances are relevant and appropriate to the student's course of learning. Students should have the opportunity to choose sources/interpretations/texts as appropriate.

If the student accompanies themselves, for example by singing and playing an instrument, then the role to be assessed should be agreed beforehand between the teacher and student.

### Task taking

Students must perform a minimum of one solo piece (of at least one minute) and a minimum of one ensemble piece (of at least one minute). The combined duration of the two performances must be at least four minutes in length.

Performances can be worked on at any point but must be recorded and assessed in the academic year in which the student expects to be awarded the qualification.

### Guided maximum performance times

There is no maximum time limit to students' combined performance. Excessively long submissions may be self-penalising.

The guided maximum time for the combined performance (both solo and ensemble) is six minutes. Performances exceeding the maximum time will still be marked.

### Performance preparation

Students can undertake preparatory work outside the classroom, for example research and performance practice.

### Feedback

Teachers may help students to understand rubrics, assessment criteria and controls. Teachers may also help students with their performance choices, styles and techniques. Any additional feedback must be recorded on the *Performance Authentication Sheet*, please see *Appendix 1*.

## Resources

Students must have equal access to IT resources. Students should have access to a range of resources/texts to enable them to make choices as required for their tasks.

## Performance assessment

### Authenticity

Students' performances must be recorded live, unedited, without interruptions and without the teacher giving guidance. If students wish to re-record a performance, they must re-record the whole performance (either solo or ensemble), and not just part of it. The teacher must be present during the recordings. Recordings of performances (using any instruments and/or technology) must not be edited afterwards.

If performing more than one piece of music as part of their solo and/or ensemble performances, the pieces of music must be performed and recorded together.

### Items for submission for moderation

#### 1. Recording

Centres must submit a complete and unedited recording of the live performance via the online submission platform Learner Work Transfer (LWT). The work of each student should be a separate track, individually labelled with their centre number, candidate number and title.

#### 2. Score

Where a written score or lead sheet exists, this must be submitted with the recording of the performance. If a piece has been learnt aurally, a professional reference recording may be submitted in addition.

If a written score or lead sheet does not exist, appropriate reference material must be submitted (a professional reference recording, written commentary, stimulus for improvised performances, track sheets, tables or diagrams).

Notated music must be provided for all performances from a score. This music must contain all the information necessary to assess the accuracy of the performance, for example, a guitar tab score with no indication of rhythm is unacceptable: scores should use conventional staff notation. Deviations from the score in jazz/rock and musical theatre numbers will generally be accepted where they are considered to be stylistically convincing.

For performances from a score/lead sheet, photocopies of the music must be submitted with the recording. Only the part performed needs to be submitted, for example just the clarinet part in a piece for clarinet with piano accompaniment. Original copies should not be supplied. Photocopies will be destroyed by Pearson at the end of the examination period.



For realising music using music technology, a detailed commentary and/or a professional reference recording must be submitted alongside a written score/lead sheet (if one exists). For sequenced performances, only the recording of the live track will be assessed. This track must be indicated when submitting.

These scores/lead sheets and/or reference materials should include as much detail as possible to allow the teacher and moderator to make a fair and accurate judgement on the quality and accuracy of the performance. The scores/lead sheets and/or reference materials are not assessed and receive no marks.

Performances that are not accompanied by acceptable scores/lead sheets/reference materials cannot be assessed.

### **3. Performance Authentication Sheet**

The Performance Authentication Sheet (PAS) must be completed by the teacher, and signed by the student and teacher, authenticating that the work is the student's own. Please see *Appendix 1*.